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ECONOMICS

Thailand

Thailand Economics

Looking Beyond Fuel Price Hikes

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Fuel Subsidies Rolled Back as Trade-Offs Sharpen

The government rolled back subsidies of pump prices on 26 March, as the financial burden of funding discounted diesel and gasoline became unsustainably high (at around THB2bn per day). As a result of the abrupt shift, diesel prices jumped 18% (THB 6/liter) in a day while other types of gasoline posted price increases of 14 to 22%. While necessary, the withdrawal of generous fuel subsidies will ripple throughout the economy, and lead to significantly higher headline inflation. GDP growth, which had originally been shielded by fuel subsidies, will be dampened as demand responds to price surges.

Targeted Measures to Ease Economic Pain

To moderate the fallout from supply chain shocks, Cabinet this week approved seven urgent measures, including steps to cut excise duties on fuel, raise the monthly top-ups for some 13.4 million low-income Welfare Card recipients from THB300 to THB400 and offer subsidies for transport sector operators including truckers and bus companies. Waiving fuel excise taxes, currently at THB5/6 per liter, is equivalent to THB15-17bn in savings for consumers. Besides targeted fiscal support for vulnerable households and industries, policymakers have taken a three-pronged approach to resolving the Gulf War's supply disruptions, namely through demand management, price management and supply augmentation.

Raise CPI Inflation Forecast to 1.9% in 2026, Could Exceed BOT Target if War Extends Beyond 1H26

We raise our headline inflation forecast to 1.9% in 2026 (from 0.8%) and 1.6% in 2027 (from 1.2%) given the subsidy rationalization, based on the assumption that energy prices stay at the current elevated levels for three months, and oil prices average US$75-80 for the year. However, in the event that the Iran War extends beyond 1H 2026, and the global oil crunch remains severe for the rest of the year, headline inflation could average more than 3% in 2026 and 2027, exceeding the Bank of Thailand's target range of 1-3%.

GDP Growth Seen at +1.5% in 2026—Manufacturing, Transport, Agriculture Affected; Silver Lining for Tourism

We trim our GDP growth forecast to +1.5% in 2026 (from +1.8%) and maintain our forecast at +2.5% in 2027. Generous fuel subsidies have previously shielded the economy from the full brunt of the Gulf energy shock. With domestic pump prices being freed to move with market forces, and with second-round effects on broader goods and services, domestic demand, especially consumption, will likely take a hit. Industries impacted by Gulf War disruptions include manufacturing, transport, agriculture and tourism. But the tourism industry should see a silver lining in diverted transit flows from Gulf hubs, as well as "safe haven" visitor demand. Faced with a mix of heightened inflation and slower GDP growth, the BOT will likely refrain from hiking its policy rate in 2026.

"Today's situation is a major global energy crisis. Everyone has to adapt. If we try to go against market prices, it will create distortions. Anything that goes against the pricing mechanism will lead to stockpiling and hoarding, and we will waste resources and budget in unnecessary areas."

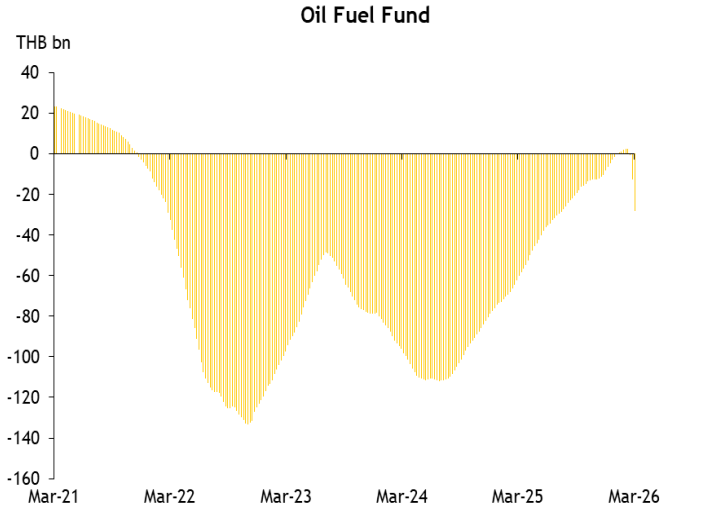
- Deputy Prime Minister and Finance Minister Ekniti Nitithanprapas, 25 March 2026

Fuel Subsidies Rolled Back as Trade-Offs Sharpen

The government rolled back subsidies of pump prices on 26 March, as the financial burden of funding discounted diesel and gasoline became unsustainably high. As a result of the abrupt shift, diesel prices jumped 18% (THB 6/liter) in a day while other types of gasoline posted price increases of 14 to 22%. The move was prompted by the widening losses at the government's Oil Fuel Fund, as it strained to absorb the difference between rising market costs and artificially low pump prices. The government will move from blanket subsidies to targeted support for groups hard-hit by the Gulf War crisis.

The Oil Fuel Fund's director for policy and strategy, Pornchai Jirakulpisan, said that deficits at the fund had snowballed to THB35bn (US$1.1bn), as international gasoil benchmarks surged sharply in the past three days. According to the latest data, the fund sustained losses of THB2.2bn per day in the past week (Fig 1).

Fig 1: Thailand Oil Fuel Fund Deficit Widened by THB15bn in the Week Ended 22 March 2026, But the Cumulative Loss Remains Below 2022 Peaks



Source: Oil Fuel Fund Office

Before the Gulf War broke out, public debt was projected to reach 68% of GDP in 2027 (shy of the statutory 70% ceiling). With little visibility as to when the global energy crunch would end, maintaining fuel price caps would have jeopardized fiscal discipline.

While necessary, the withdrawal of generous fuel subsidies will ripple throughout the economy, and lead to significantly higher headline inflation. GDP growth, which had originally been shielded by fuel subsidies from the brunt of the Gulf supply shock, will be dampened as demand responds to price surges.

The withdrawal of Oil Fuel Fund subsidies of pump prices should help to alleviate the differential pricing that gave rise to spiking demand at gas stations. The Federation of Thailand Industries reported that the Oil Fuel Fund only subsidized

retail prices of diesel, while the industrial sector bought fuel via "jobbers" which received no subsidies. The resultant gap of as high as 10 baht per liter opened up in recent days – incentivizing businesses, including SMEs, to queue up at gas stations instead. As a factory's fuel consumption was equivalent to that of 50–100 cars, the redirection of their purchases to retail pumps contributed to the latter's onsite supplies being depleted.

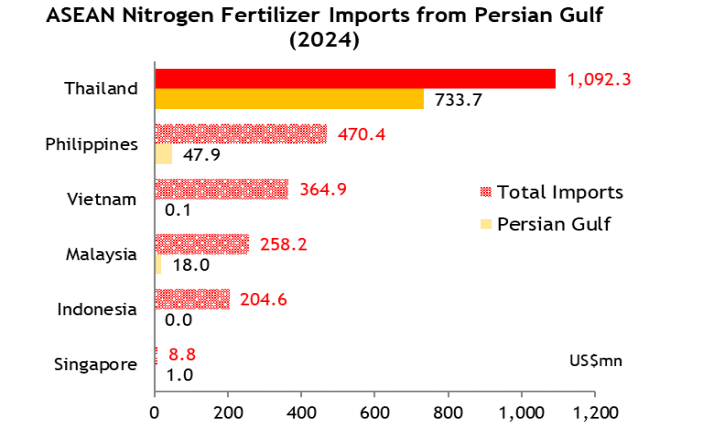
Government Approves Targeted Measures to Ease Economic Pain

To moderate the fallout from supply chain shocks, Cabinet this week approved seven urgent measures, including steps to cut excise duties on fuel, raise the monthly top-ups for some 13.4 million low-income Welfare Card recipients from THB300 to THB400 and offer subsidies for transport sector operators including truckers and bus companies. Waiving fuel excise taxes, currently at THB5/6 per liter for diesel and gasoline, should bring THB15-17bn in savings for consumers.

The government also sought to provide discounted fertilizers and organic alternatives for farmers under the Green Flag (Thong Khiao) scheme. The Persian Gulf is a critical source of fertilizers for the kingdom's agricultural sector.

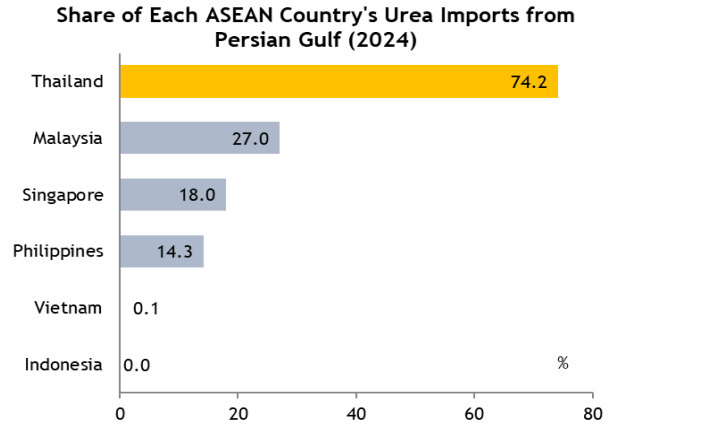
Two-thirds of its nitrogen fertilizer imports were sourced from the Gulf. An even larger 74% of its imports of urea fertilizer (the most widely-used nitrogen fertilizer) came from the Gulf 9Figs 2 and 3). Dearer fertilizers in the important planting season for crops such as rice and maize (starting in April/May) could affect planting decision and hurt harvests down the road in late 2026, crimping output and raising raw food prices.

Fig 2: Thailand Was the Most Dependent on Gulf Nitrogen Fertilizer …



Note: Nitrogen products refers to HS3102
Source: International Trade Centre

Fig 3: … Particularly in Urea Fertilizer - 74% of Thailand's and 14% of the Philippines' Urea Are Imported from Gulf



Note: Urea products refers to HS310210
Source: International Trade Centre

Fishermen will be supported in switching to B20 biodiesel. For government contractors, flexibility will be given to accommodate unexpected cost increases. For SMEs, the Government Savings Bank plans to set aside THB10bn in soft loans to tide businesses over cash-flow constraints.

Although the quantum of financial support was not announced, we expect this sum to be rather more modest compared with the fuel subsidies being phased out—as it would otherwise defeat the purpose of preserving fiscal discipline. The funding size could, in the first instance, increase the budget deficit by 0.5% point to 4.5% of GDP this year. Thereafter, if the Gulf situation becomes drawn out, more off-budget measures could be rolled out. If needed, the government has leeway to tap THB300bn in available funds to go towards the consumption scheme "Khon La

Khrueng". The finance ministry stated that there was no need to raise the public debt ceiling of 70% of GDP thus far.

Raise CPI Inflation Forecast to 1.9% in 2026, Could Exceed BOT Target if War Extends Beyond 1H26

We raise our headline inflation forecast to 1.9% in 2026 (from 0.8%) and 1.6% in 2027 (from 1.2%) given the subsidy rationalization, based on the assumption that energy prices stay at the current elevated levels for three months, and oil prices average US$75-80 for the year.

Transport fuel accounts for 7.3% of the Consumer Price Index (CPI) basket, and electricity another 4.5% (Table 1), one of the largest exposures in the region. Beyond the direct impact on household's fuel and utility bills, there will be lagged price increases on broad swathes of goods and services, as businesses pass on higher costs to consumers.

However, in the event that the Iran War extends beyond 1H26, and the global oil crunch remains severe for the rest of the year, headline inflation could average more than 3% in 2026 and 2027, exceeding the Bank of Thailand's target range of 1-3%.

Table 1: Energy and Food Weights in ASEAN-6 CPI Baskets

	Energy			Food		
	Total Energy	Transport Fuel	Utilities	Total	Uncooked Food	Prepared Food/ Food Services
Thailand	11.9	7.4	4.5	35.1	18.2	16.9
Indonesia	11.5	4.8	6.7	32.9	22.5	10.4
Philippines	9.1	2.4	6.7	44.3	34.8	9.5
Malaysia	9.0	5.9	3.1	29.0	15.6	13.4
Singapore	3.8	1.8	2.0	20.4	6.5	13.9
Vietnam*		10.0		35.9	26.5	9.4

*Note: * Vietnam data refers to transport weight in CPI basket. Petrol costs make up 4% of the CPI basket.*
Transport fuel includes diesel, gasoline, oil/lubricant, utilities includes electricity, gas and other fuels
Source: CEIC

Faced with a mix of heightened inflation and slower GDP growth, the BOT is likely to refrain from hiking its policy rate this year. The central bank would probably be mindful of a substantial negative output gap, and be inclined to keep interest rates at 1.00% until end-2027. The government would probably continue to rely on administrative measures to add friction to price increases.

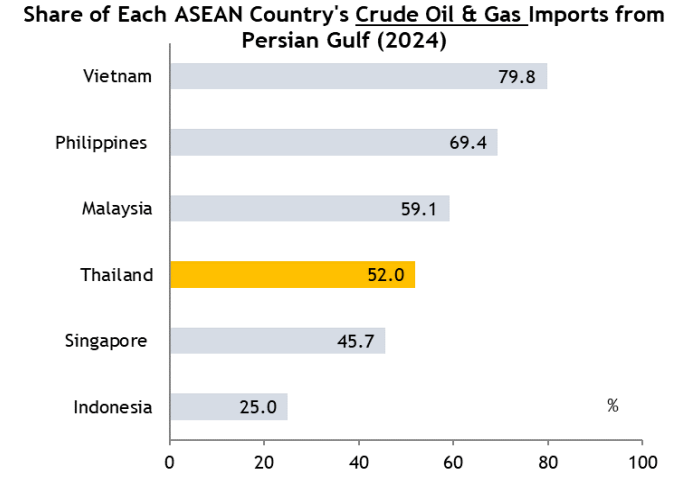
Three-Pronged Approach to Buffer Against War Disruptions

The month-long blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has choked off supplies of critical commodities from the Persian Gulf to the world. These include fuel, petrochemical feed stocks (for plastics), sulphur (for metal production), helium (for chipmaking) and nitrogen fertilizers (for farming). The kingdom is relatively less exposed to the Gulf for imports of oil and gas, among ASEAN countries (Fig 4 and 5).

Besides targeted fiscal support for vulnerable households and industries, policymakers have taken a three-pronged approach to resolving the Gulf War's supply disruptions, namely through demand management, price management and supply augmentation.

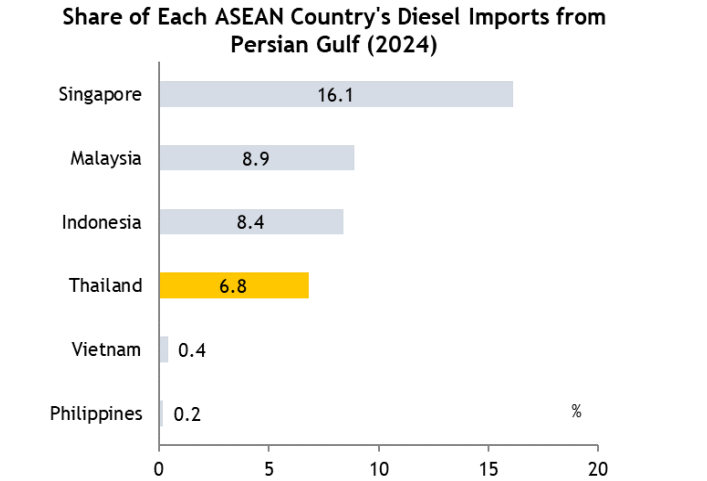
Demand Management: Measures to lower energy demand include the adoption of working-from-home for public service workers, raise air-conditioning temperatures to 26 degrees, and reduce overseas trips.

Fig 1: Thailand is Relatively Less Exposed to the Gulf for its Crude Oil and Gas Imports (52%)



Note: Crude oil refers to HS2709
Source: International Trade Centre

Fig 2: Only 6.8% of Thailand's Diesel Imports Came from the Gulf



Note: Diesel products refers to HS271019
Source: International Trade Centre

The Energy Regulatory Commission (ERC) is preparing to announce adjustments to power tariffs for the May-August cycle, with options of between THB3.95 to 4.59 per KW hour, a 2 to 18% hike from the prevailing THB3.88. The increases are likely to elicit efforts at energy conservation.

Price Management: Officials this month announced initiatives to crack down on fuel and goods price-gouging. Sellers of essential goods from a list of price-controlled goods will need approval from the Department of Internal Trade before hiking certain prices, or are required to announce price changes for some products.

Supply Augmentation: To ensure ample supplies, the government imposed a ban on exports of refined fuels (except to selected neighboring countries). It has also worked to secure alternative import sources for energy and fertilizers, after shipments from the Gulf were affected. The kingdom has around 100 days of oil reserves. ("Thai Market Compass: This Too Shall Pass", 25 March 2026)

In addition, officials have reached out to exporters such as Brazil, Kazakhstan and Nigeria for alternative oil supplies. Domestic gas extraction from the Gulf of Thailand is also being ramped up to the maximum. In terms of fertilizers, the kingdom's existing supplies last until May, with more shipments secured that should last until this August.

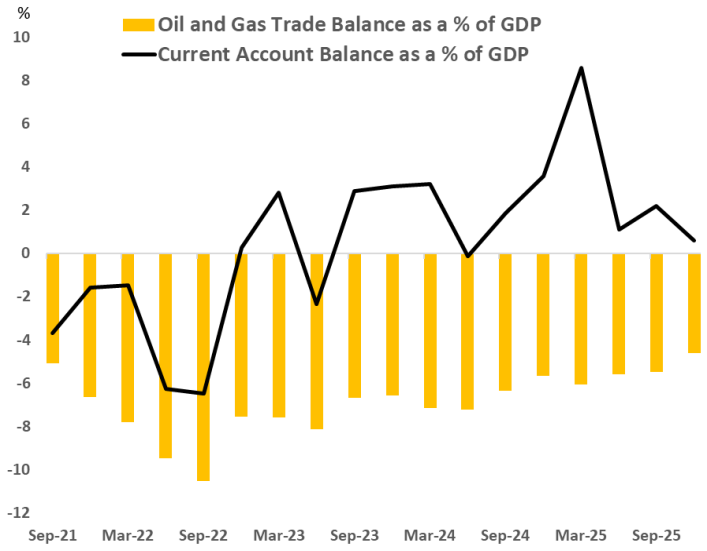
Oil and Gas Trade Deficit to Compress Current Account Balance

Under the baseline that the Gulf disruption eases by end-1H 2026, the oil and gas trade deficit is projected to widen to US$37bn (6.3% of GDP) in 2026 from US$31bn (5.4% of GDP) in 2025 (Fig 6).

This is on account of the rising cost of energy imports, as well as a plunge in energy exports due to the ban on overseas sales of refined products. Refined fuel products accounted for 95.4% of the kingdom's oil and gas exports in 2025. Besides policy-

induced export declines, overseas demand for agricultural products and vehicles would also be affected by economic slowdowns in the Gulf, on top of soaring shipping insurance costs. The Middle East accounted for 17% of Thai rice exports, and 21% of its automotive shipments.

Fig 6: The Oil and Gas Trade Deficit Averaged 5.4% of GDP in 2025, While the Current Account Posted a Mild Annual Surplus (3.1% of GDP)



Source: CEIC , Maybank IBG Research

Consequently, the current account balance is likely to narrow from a previously forecast US$12bn (2% of GDP) to US$7bn (1.2% of GDP). A prolonged Iran War risks tipping the current account balance into a modest deficit, as was the case with the energy shock in 2022. At present, our FX team forecasts the baht to end of this year at 32.50 versus the dollar, 1% stronger than the current 32.91.

GDP Growth Seen Falling to +1.5% in 2026—Manufacturing, Transport, Agriculture More Affected

We lower our GDP growth forecast to +1.5% in 2026 (from +1.8%) and maintain our forecast at +2.5% in 2027. Generous fuel subsidies have previously shielded the economy from the full brunt of the Gulf energy shock. With domestic pump prices being freed to move with market forces, and with second-round effects on broader goods and services, domestic demand, especially consumption, will be affected. Net exports will also be crimped on slower global growth, as well as fuel export curbs. Conversely, fixed investment should stay resilient in 2026-2027, on a strong pipeline of private and public projects.

Industries affected by Gulf War disruptions include manufacturing, transport, agriculture and tourism. The **wholesale and retail trade** industry should be better-insulated given increased stockpiling needs, alongside the **electronics** industry, which is buoyed by AI-driven hardware orders.

Within **manufacturing** (23.9% of GDP), higher raw material costs and interrupted supplies amid low capacity utilization would weigh on low-margin segments such as light manufacturing, while energy-intensive heavy industrials such as steel and cement production could face elevated utility bills.

The **transport and storage** sector (6.9% of GDP) would experience the most immediate impact from an energy shocks. The sector was expanding at +3.2% in 4Q25 on moderating activity. However, the government today announced a support scheme to blunt the blow.

On 27 March, the Transport Ministry proposed a fuel compensation scheme for heavy trucks (THB6/liter), large public buses (THB4/liter), small public vehicles such as songthaews and vans (THB300 per vehicle/day) and motorcycle taxis and delivery riders (THB300 per vehicle/month).

The financial aid will last for the month of April. In addition, the ministry asked that transport fares be kept unchanged for as long as possible, and pledged to introduce biofuels at a special price for transport operators.

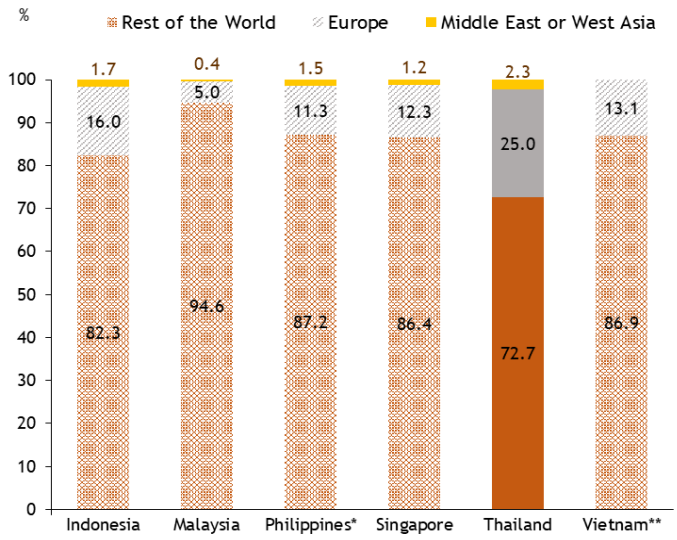
The **agricultural** sector (7.4%) could experience the lagged effects of fertilizer price inflation in 2H 2026, if the planting season in April/May for crops such as maize and rice is affected. After posting soft growth in the previous quarter (+0.3%) on falling yields and crop prices, a mild recovery was projected for the agricultural sector this year.

Incentives are being introduced to nudge farmers to reduce their reliance on nitrogenous chemical fertilizers, and switch to organic fertilizers, to ensure that the key planting season is not affected. The return of El Nino weather conditions from June 2026, which would herald drier conditions, is a risk to monitor.

Tourism – A Silver Lining in "Safe Haven" Tourists

For the important **tourism** industry, the Iran War will, on net, reduce visitor arrivals—but with a silver lining. Our tourism analyst Boonyakorn Amornsank is projecting arrivals of 34 million in 2026, a reduction of 1.4 million from the previous forecast for this year. ("Thailand Aviation: Travel Demand Hiccups from Tension in the Middle East", 12 March 2026). Year-to-date (as of 22 Mar), visitor arrivals fell -3% y-o-y to 8.5 million.

Fig 7: Visitors from the Middle East and Europe Make Up a Combined 27.3% of Thailand's Arrivals, the Highest in ASEAN-6



*Note: *Philippines data covers January-November 2025, ** For Vietnam, "Rest of the World" includes the Middle East.*

Source: CEIC , Maybank IBG Research

Middle East and European travelers make up a quarter of all visitor arrivals (Fig 7). With a third of Europe-Asia flights transiting through the Gulf, European visitor numbers will face near-term headwinds as those routes are disrupted.

However, Thailand's air hub activity is likely to see a pick-up, as Europe-Asia transit volumes are diverted from Gulf airports. For example, Thai Airways has ramped up flight frequency to key European capitals for the summer season, to take advantage of rerouted Europe-Asia demand from Middle Eastern transit passengers

The kingdom may also pick up "safe haven" tourists from Asia that are deterred from long-haul destinations out of either cost or safety considerations A case in point is the latest week's visitor inflows, which rose +7.5% from the preceding week, due to a +15% rise in short-haul travelers and post-Ramadan tourists from Malaysia, Indonesia and the Middle East including Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates.

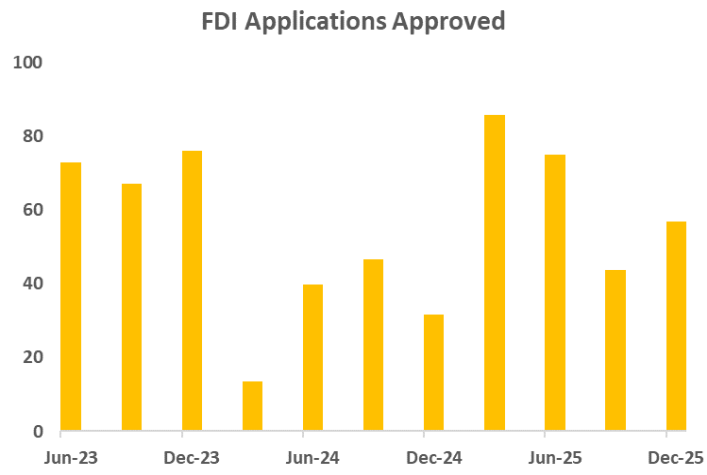
In addition, the tourism sector should continue to benefit from recovering China demand, as a result of Chinese holidaymakers' preferences shifting away from Japan. We expect Chinese visitor numbers to rebound from 4.5m in 2025 to 6m this year.

Industrial Investment to Anchor GDP Growth in 2027 and Beyond

Looking beyond the turbulence of 2026, the economic is likely to post firm medium-term growth on the back of policy stability, infrastructure renewal and strong foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows. We project that GDP growth will recover from +1.5% this year to +2.5% in 2027 (Table 2).

Expansion in 2027 will be anchored by the implementation of industrial capex, as the value of approved FDI applications rose to a record THB1.14 trillion last year (+56.9%) (Fig 8), driven by the digital, electronics and automotive industries.

Fig 8: Approved FDI Applications by the BOI Surged +56.9% in 2025 to a High of THB1.14 trillion



Source: CEIC, Thailand Board of Investment

Table 2: Thailand - Key Macroeconomic Indicators

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026F	2027F
Real GDP (%)	**2.6**	**2.2**	**2.9**	**2.4**	**1.5**	**2.5**
Private Consumption (%)	6.3	6.7	4.4	2.7	1.5	2.9
Government Consumption (%)	0.1	(4.6)	2.6	0.6	1.7	2.0
Gross Fixed Capital Formation (%)	2.3	1.2	(0.3)	4.9	1.8	2.0
Exports of Goods & Services (%)	6.4	2.7	7.5	9.2	2.0	2.5
Imports of Goods & Services (%)	3.4	(2.5)	5.7	6.7	3.6	2.4
Current Account Balance (% of GDP)	(3.4)	1.6	2.2	3.1	1.2	2.0
Fiscal Balance (% of GDP)	(3.5)	(3.3)	(4.0)	(4.8)	(4.5)	(4.1)
Inflation Rate (%, period average)	6.1	1.2	0.4	(0.1)	1.9	1.6
Unemployment Rate (%, period average)	1.3	1.0	1.0	0.8	1.3	1.2
Exchange Rate (per USD, end-period)	34.6	34.26	34.10	31.51	32.50	31.00
Benchmark Interest Rate (% p.a., end-period)	1.25	2.50	2.25	1.25	1.00	1.00

Source: CEIC, Maybank IBG Research

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